



VCU Student Financial Management Center at Harris Hall on Aug. 18. Photo By Burke Loftus.

VCU Students face higher than average tuition increase

SAL ORLANDO
News Editor

MAEVE BAUER
Executive Editor

VCU in-state undergraduate students are now paying 3.9% more on their tuition this academic year.

In-state undergraduate students enrolled in 15 credits per semester are now paying \$17,963 in tuition and mandatory fees, according to VCU News.

Virginia's average increase in tuition for in-state undergraduates is 3.2%, according to the State Council of Higher Education for Virginia. VCU had the second highest percentage increase in the state, behind Old Dominion University.

Almost 80% of registered voters in Virginia's July 2026 Commonwealth Poll believe that cost is too high to attend college in Virginia, reflecting a 10% increase since the winter poll.

Tuition Increase Continued on page 3

NEWS

VCU POLL: Virginians express concerns over data center impacts

SAL ORLANDO,
News Editor

The L. Douglas Wilder School of Government and Public Affairs released a new Commonwealth Poll on July 15 with results showing Virginians are pushing back against data centers.

Nearly 8 in 10 registered voters in Virginia believe data centers should pay additional fees to compensate for increased electricity demands from facility operation, according to the poll. Over 70% of registered voters oppose data centers receiving sales tax exemptions that incentivize facilities in the state.

Virginia leads the country in the most planned data centers, according to Pew Research Center. There are future facilities planned for Chesterfield, Henrico, Petersburg and Goochland.

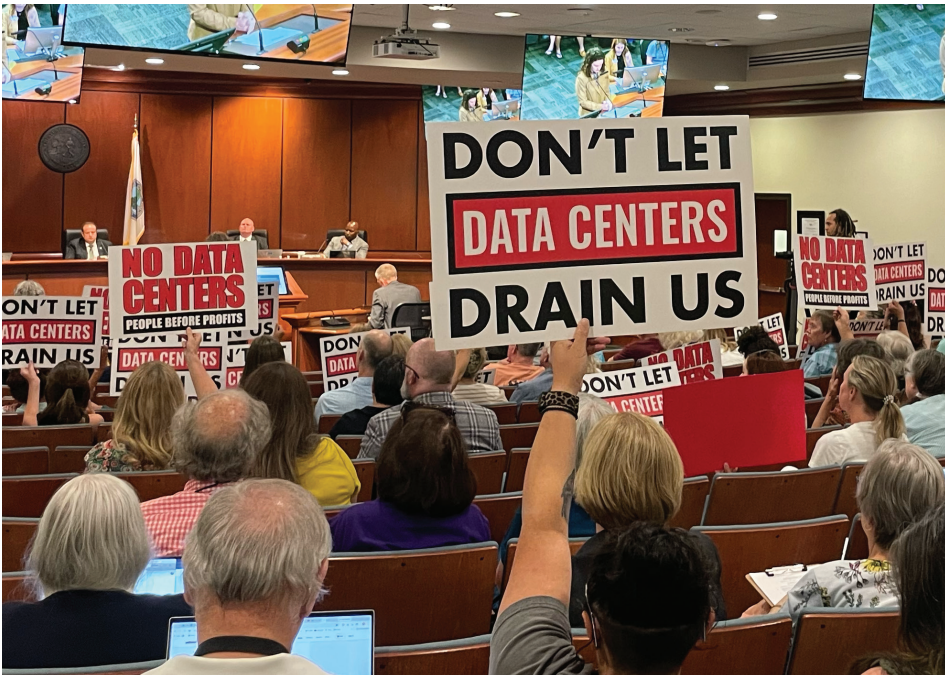
Mary Finley-Brook, Professor of Geography and Global Studies at the University of Richmond and member of Data Center Defiance, said that Google, Meta, QTS, Chirisa and Tracts are all well-known entities in the data center landscape building in the Richmond area.

DCD is a coalition in Central Virginia with the mission of protecting people and

the environment from the harms of data centers in the region.

"They're trying to squeeze as much as they can out of every locality, and it is always a sense of 'If you don't go along with what's being demanded, they we will go elsewhere,'" Finley-Brook said. "So, local governments feel a little bit over the barrel... I think they are misinformed about the risks."

DATA CENTERS Continued on page 4



Sign at Chesterfield Google Data Center Open House. Courtesy of Data Center Defiance.

SPECTRUM

HOTPANTS finds its sound in Richmond rock scene



HOTPANTS lead singer and guitarist Mackenzie Roark performing at the Woodland Heights Tiny Porch Concert series on Aug. 16. Photo by Burke Loftus

RACHEL NICHOLAS
Assistant Spectrum Editor

In a city full of creativity and booming artistry, Richmond rock band HOTPANTS has spent the last few years finding their place in the city's music scene, pulling inspiration from classic rock, indie and psychedelic music.

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Baseball Season Recap

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Mom! Phineas and Ferb are making an improv show!

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Why opinions matter — even the ones you don't agree with

see OPINIONS page 16

On This Day
On this day, Aug. 19, Dogwood Dell held its 3rd free annual festival of Virginia Fiddling as part of Richmond’s Festival of Arts series. The day



Kylie, the founder of Honeycomb Haus, a floral design company is showing off an array of beautifully flowers at the Pollinator Palooza. Photo by Catt Brito.

Buzz-worthy day at Pollinator Palooza

AALIYAH SHARROCK
Contributing Writer

What brings people together to learn about native plants, butterflies and bees? For the attendees of Pollinator Palooza, the answer may be as simple as curiosity or even a desire to better understand the ecosystems around them.

That connection was on display at Pollinator Palooza located at Studio Two Three on Aug. 16, where educators, vendors and community members gathered to learn about pollinators, native plants and the relationship between people and nature.

The free event offered visitors an opportunity to learn about pollinators,

explore native plants and interact with local businesses and educators.

Yelena Avigail, an educator at the event, is a butterfly expert who showcased artwork, stickers and watercolor paintings while teaching visitors about moths and butterflies.

“My favorite pollinators are moths and I think they are very misunderstood because people think that they are here to eat our clothes, but most beautiful moths don’t even have mouths,” Avigail said.

One of Avigail’s favorite pollinators is the snowberry clearwing moth, a daytime-flying moth that mimics the appearance of a bee. Visitors were also particularly interested in the Atlas moth at her booth.

The moth came from Southeast Asia and was raised through its entire life cycle before she used it for educational purposes, according to Avigail.

Kirwin Patmon, owner of The Lit Bae Bookshop, stated the event offered a way to explore the relationship between nature and people’s everyday lives. Patmon runs a Richmond-based pop-up bookshop that travels throughout the DMV area and features books for the LGBTQ+ and Black community.

There is a growing selection of nonfiction about nature that also explores how people interact with the natural world, according to Patmon.

“I think because of how most pollinators

are small, people think, ‘Oh, it’s just a bee,’ but without them we don’t live or exist,” Patmon said.

Other vendors connected nature to their own creative work.

Kimberly Griffiths, owner of RVA Petal Party, showcased jewelry, accessories and fresh flowers. She previously worked in horticulture and began preserving flowers in jewelry after combining her interest in plants with her love of jewelry.

Griffiths said one of the most important things for people to understand about pollinators is how essential they are to everyday life.

“People don’t know how essential they are to the world, we need them for crops and food as well as all the fruits and vegetables that we have,” Griffiths said.

Kylie Newcomb, owner of Honeycomb Haus, focuses on creating bouquets and allowing attendees to make their own. She prioritizes native flowers and plants in her work as a florist due to her interest in connecting people with the land, according to Newcomb.

Through education, art, flowers and community conversations, the variety of pollinators featured at the event gave visitors an opportunity to learn about creatures up close and personal.

PHINEAS AND FERB

TJ PARRILLO
Contributing Writer

Richmond’s Coalition Theater, located at 8 W. Broad St., wants to bring out not just the actors, but the audience’s creative side in their upcoming “Phineas and Ferb” themed improv show.

“Phineas and Ferb” is not just about two boys navigating the boredom of summer, it is also about imagination and collaboration.

When adapting any series from pre-recorded and scripted to live and improvised, one must consider the many trade-offs of the respective mediums. To elevate their source material, Richmond Coalition Theater uses features including

audience interactions and a live band providing music for improvised musical numbers. With no two episodes the same, each performance echoes the line “So Ferb, what do you want to do today?” with a twist of audience interaction.

When audience members arrive at the theater, they write down an invention they would like Phineas and Ferb to build, said cast member Blake Vail-Rhodes. The director, Preston Bradsher, then picks two suggestions, which become the episode titles and the inventions.

The show is PG and there is veto power for any inappropriate suggestions.

“Our actors bring their own voice and interpretation to the characters, but when casting we purposefully prioritized casting

people who know the show very well,” Vail-Rhodes said.

Theater’s long history as a form of storytelling speaks to a fundamental human desire for connection, according to Vail-Rhodes. Experiencing stories through a screen can create a sense of distance between audiences and the stories they consume.

“Movies get pretty close, but there isn’t a thing on earth like live theater,” Vail-Rhodes said.

There are two episodes per show, following the same beat format - alternating between the characters Phineas and friends, Candace and Perry and Doofenshmirtz, said cast member under the stage name Zukini Lesagna.

“I feel like with any long form improvising, you just need to make two strong decisions, either physical or emotional and your scene partners will take care of it,” Lesagna said.

These suggestions are not only a product of the audience’s imagination. On the back wall of the stage, a felt piece is used during a “quirky worky” song where actors place random velcro objects, turning the imagination into invention.

Expect the hallmarks of the original show, including all kinds of inventions, evil schemes, parental hobbies and failed bust attempts, said cast member Sam Rizzo.

The show will have performances on Aug. 21, Aug. 28 and Sept. 4.



Illustration courtesy Zoë Luis.



Performers at the 3rd annual International Dance Festival, held in Glen Allen on Saturday. Photo by John Brown.

Culture takes center stage at Richmond’s 3rd annual International Dance Festival

SADIE PORTER
Contributing Writer

Traditional dancers from over 18 countries, spanning from India to China to Mexico, congregated at the Cultural Arts Center at Glenn Allen on Aug. 15 for the 3rd annual Richmond International Dance Festival as a celebration of diversity and community.

From only representing a mere five countries at the first festival, to 16, to finally this year representing a total of 18 countries, the Richmond International Dance Festival has reached its largest audience yet.

Culture Encounters presented the event — a nonprofit organization that aims to bring immigrants in the Richmond region together. The immersive experience includes community dinners, school visits and workplace programs.

Amma Gatty, founder and executive director of Culture Encounters has seen

the changes firsthand, starting out as an art summer camp for kids before shifting its focus to the exploration of cultures.

“The idea is for immigrants and locals to have spaces where they can truly connect and engage with each other,” Gatty said.

As culturally diverse as Richmond is, ethnic groups are separate into their own communities, isolating different cultural groups, according to Gatty.

The dance festival highlighted the importance of multi-cultural appreciation within the city of Richmond with community members gathered outside in the summer heat to support their family and friends.

“Every place has its own love language, whether that’s through food, language, culture or dance,” said Matthew Davenport, a festival attendee.

Seeing people from all cultures and identities come together in one place and sharing how they celebrate is meaningful, according to Davenport.

This kind of event encourages people to tap into their own cultural identity and allows individuals to show their appreciation for other countries’ traditions, Davenport said.

“There’s a lot of different opportunities for folks to kind of pick up a new hobby or learn something new,” said Christina Steward, a festival attendee.

Eric Luu, an experienced break dancer of 15 years, represents breaking and was a returning performer at the International Dance Festival, not representing a specific country.

From an early age, Luu had a lot of energy and was drawn to music, often dancing along and imitating moves he saw on television and the internet. He knew breaking was his niche after watching “America’s Best Dance Crew” and learning from a friend of his cousin.

Since then, Luu has competed nationally along the East Coast as a member of his own dance crew, Mystical Space

Typhoon, while also serving as a judge at competitions and workshopping.

“This year feels more exciting,” Luu said.

Luu felt more confident in the promoters of the International Dance Festival this year due to having the Cultural Arts Center as the primary location with a more consolidated space, rather than the non-dedicated event space used years before.

“I think the work that culture encounters does, fills a space in Richmond that a lot of organizations try to do, which is to combine cultures and get people exposed to new types of thinking, new ways of living and about cultures that don’t usually get a spotlight,” Luu said.

et Features

RVA Spotlight
Wondering who’s bad? Head to the National this Friday the 21st at 8 pm for the number one Michael Jackson tribute band! All ages are welcome and tickets are currently available on their website, whosbadmusic.com.



Hotpants guitarist and vocalist Billy Bacci performing at the Woodland Heights Tiny Porch Concert series on Aug. 16. Photo by Burke Loftus

HOTPANTS

Although they gather ideas from a multitude of places, the band agrees that assigning a genre to their sound is not so simple.

“People will ask us, ‘What kind of music do you play?’ I’m just like, ‘I don’t know,’” frontwoman Mackenzie Roark said.

HOTPANTS formed after Roark released her first album in 2022 and wanted to bring the songs to a live audience. The band’s current lineup came together through years of connections between Richmond musicians, eventually becoming what Roark considers the “core of Hotpants.”

Roark first met guitarist and bassist Billy Bacci around 2017 at an open mic event she was running. Bacci also previously played with drummer Drew Barnocky and bassist Matt Moran through another band they were in together.

“Paint on it was a band that me, Matt, and Drew were in,” Bacci said. “We made three albums together, and I met Matt through his brother and Drew was playing for Mackenzie at the time.”

When it came time to build the band, the existing relationships made the process easier, the answer later evolving into the group HOTPANTS.

The name, a throwback to the retro term for short shorts popularized in the 1970s, took a bit longer for the band to settle on. Roark wanted something that captured the band’s style while also giving them a name they could incorporate into their stage presence.

“I’ve been drawn to music from the ‘60 and 70s since middle and high school,” Roark said. “I think the rock genre is more home for me. It’s what I grew up listening to and the reason I wanted to start making music myself.”

Roark remembers watching “School of Rock” in sixth grade and immediately wanting to start a band. The idea had already existed when she was younger, when she and her friends would talk about becoming musicians.

Bacci also cited the movie as a source of inspiration, even having a hypothetical childhood band titled Space Dudes.

The band members bring different musical influences to the group, something

they said has helped shape its sound. Roark draws from older rock and folk music, while other members bring influences from indie, noise and psychedelic rock.

Bacci said his background is more rooted in indie and noise rock, including bands such as Pixies, while Moran brings an interest in improvisational music and Phish, along with other modern rock influences.

The differences allow the members to contribute their own styles while still building around Roark’s songwriting.

“We all know how to speak a common musical language, and our influences are so similar,” Bacci said. “And I feel like we know pretty quickly if it’s gonna click on a song or if it’s just worth moving on from.”

“When we collaborate, it’s awesome because everyone brings something different,” Bacci said. “Mackenzie writes these songs that have like a central thesis and Matt has an amazing ability to just jump in an improv.”

That process has allowed HOTPANTS to move between different sounds without worrying too much about where the music fits.

The band can play alongside country, folk or punk acts because of the range of sounds they incorporate.

Their first show together was as an opening act at the Camel, a local live music venue, where they opened for another artist. The space was packed from wall to wall, and it will go down as a night they won’t forget, according to the band.

“I just remember feeling so electrified,” Roark said. “Like, there are so many people and they’re screaming for us. It kind of felt like walking on air afterwards.”

Richmond has given the band space to branch out, helping them gain traction at the local and state level, although they are still working toward building a larger national audience.

For now, HOTPANTS continues to grow within the city’s music community while developing new material and expanding its sound. For more information on their music and upcoming events, check out their website <https://www.hotpantsband.com/shows>.



Hotpants lead singer and guitarist Mackenzie Roark performing at the Woodland Heights Tiny Porch Concert series on Aug. 16. Photo by Burke Loftus

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STUDENT STAFF SPOTLIGHT

DEVAN WAGNER

Job Positions:	Year:	Major:
Resident Assistant DSA Content Creator	Junior	Mass Communications

Devan serves as a Resident Assistant with VCU Residential Life and Housing and as a Content Creator for the Division of Student Affairs. He was recognized as a spotlight recipient for his exceptional positivity, dedication, and reliability. Devan consistently shows up as his best self and gives his all to every role, making him someone his colleagues can always count on. His passion for VCU and the university community has earned him the well-deserved nickname, “Mr. VCU.” Thank you, Devan, for bringing your positivity, passion, and VCU pride to everything you do!

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